

Examining the Dynamics of Changing Tastes*

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Words: 6,300
Last Revised: 21-Jul-26

Abstract

Does cultural taste primarily flow from shifting social networks, or do durable cultural tastes help stabilize personal communities over time? Network transmission models posit that tastes are volatile and decay when social ties are disrupted, whereas cultural capital models posit that tastes are enduring dispositions that facilitate tie maintenance. Using longitudinal panel data from the Project Canada Survey (1985–1995), I adjudicate between these frameworks via discrete-time pooled logistic and Mundlak Poisson models. I find that cultural tastes exhibit remarkably high levels of over-time stability (roughly 98% retention over five years), countering standard network volatility assumptions. Furthermore, contrary to network theory expectations, when rare taste loss events do occur, they are not systematically driven by structural network turnover (e.g., disrupted friendships or geographic mobility). Furthermore, holding durable cultural breadth (omnivore tastes) longitudinally predicts higher rates of maintained social connectivity. These findings point toward a decisive advantage for the cultural capital model: tastes act as durable, selective filters that maintain social ties, while remaining highly resilient even in the face of structural network shocks.

**Data for this project were obtained from the Association of Religion Data Archives at <http://www.thearda.com>. The author bears sole responsibility for the current interpretation, analyses and tabulations of these data. I would like to thank Paul DiMaggio, Bart Bonikowski, and the members of the Princeton seminar in cultural sociology for their very useful comments on previous drafts of this paper.

Introduction

Prevailing models of taste formation, transmission, and decay in the sociology of culture posit that current tastes are largely a product of the individual's current network configuration. The standard assumption is that tastes are transmitted through existing network ties, in particular those social connections characterized by sociodemographic similarity (Lazarsfeld and Merton, 1954; McPherson and Cook, 2001). From this perspective, tastes are not enduring aspects of the person but malleable, "thin" contents liable to change when network ties change (_____, 1998b, 2003). Given that personal networks are highly volatile (Burt, 2000; Suitor and Morgan, 1997), this network perspective implies that cultural tastes should also exhibit significant instability over time.

In contrast, the cultural capital model (Bourdieu, 1984; Holt, 1998) conceives of cultural tastes as highly durable dispositions. Formed early in life, these embodied cultural practices are resistant to change and serve as stable resources to maintain and forge network connections (Lizardo, 2006). Rather than being at the mercy of shifting networks, stable cultural tastes may act as a reciprocal driver of network maintenance, enabling individuals to sustain interaction across constantly shifting personal communities.

This research note empirically adjudicates between these divergent expectations using longitudinal panel data. Specifically, I address the following research questions: (1) Do cultural tastes exhibit the high volatility implied by network transmission models, or the high stability expected by cultural capital models? (2) When cultural taste loss does occur, is it primarily driven by life-course events associated with network turnover? (3) Does a broad, stable repertoire of cultural tastes (cultural capital) longitudinally predict the maintenance of social connectivity, independent of reciprocal effects?

By leveraging the Project Canada Survey (1985-1995) and employing modern panel data estimators (discrete-time pooled logits and Mundlak within-between Poisson models), this note provides a direct test of the cultural capital versus network transmission frameworks.

Data and variables

The data for this study come from the *Project Canada Survey* (PCS). The PCS is a longitudinal study of the social attitudes and cultural practices of a representative sample of Canadian citizens extending from 1975-1995, conducted out of the University of Lethbridge. The project began data collection in 1975 with a total 1,917 respondents. Every five years since representative samples of similar size have been collected, with a "core" set of respondents that have participated in previous surveys. Because it collected data on cultural practices and patterns of social interaction and membership in important foci of social interaction (i.e. voluntary association memberships) over time for the same individuals, the PCS data provide an excellent opportunity to deal with issues of

casual order in the relationship between cultural taste loss and life-course events associated with network turnover.

In the following study, I use the longitudinal panel covering the core years of 1985, 1990, and 1995, focusing on the core set of respondents who participated across these waves. While previous analyses restricted themselves to the 1985–1990 window to avoid coding inconsistencies in 1995 and age-related taste declines, the use of modern longitudinal estimators (such as Mundlak within-between models with wave fixed-effects) allows us to gracefully handle both age-related secular trends and programmatic harmonization of the taste indicators across the entire panel timeframe.

Data Processing and Limitations. The PCS data provide a rare look at longitudinal cultural tastes, but require careful programmatic harmonization due to survey design changes across waves. First, later waves shifted to 5-point and 7-point frequency scales; these were programmatically harmonized back to the original 4-point scale (1 = Very often, 4 = Never). Second, for several out-of-home activities (e.g., going to the movies, plays), the 1990 wave entirely dropped the "Very often" category, creating structural missingness at the top of the scale. Consequently, the strict event-history models of taste loss are restricted to four consistently measured at-home activities. Finally, the raw "frequency of interaction with friends" indicator was reverse-coded (where 1 equaled "Many" and 3 equaled "Few"); this was programmatically inverted prior to estimation so that higher integer values correctly reflect greater social connectivity in the Poisson count models. There are also no direct ego-network size measures, so interaction frequency and voluntary memberships serve as proxies for sociability.

Variables

Cultural Taste indicators

Cultural taste loss indicators. The PCS collected information across the 1985, 1990, and 1995 waves related to the frequency of consumption of a variety of leisure culture activities and mass media outlets. Because of wording and coding changes across survey waves for several activities, I examine four specific at-home activities that were coded consistently over time: (1) listening to music, (2) following a sports team, (3) reading the newspaper, and (4) reading books of fiction. This selection captures a wide array of potential taste changes over time. Respondents were asked to report the frequency with which they engaged in each of these activities using the following prompt:¹

Thinking now of your life outside of formal work, how often would you estimate that you: [i.e. listen to music]?

Four categories of responses were allowed: (1) very often, (2) sometimes, (3)

¹The various codebooks for all waves of the PCS survey (1975, 1980, 1985, 1990 and 1995) are available online at: <http://www.thearda.com/Archive/IntSurveys.asp>.

Seldom and (4) Never.² Thus for each respondent (i), for a given cultural activity (k) at time (t) is defined as their score in the respective ordered categorical variable y_{ikt} .

Cultural taste breadth indicators. To assess the hypotheses connected to the effects of cultural taste on indicators of sociability and social connectivity, I created a cultural taste breadth variable for the 1980, 1985, 1990, and 1995 waves. This is a simple additive index indicating participation in a wide range of cultural activities. Using the same set of items, the respondent receives one point in the cultural taste breadth scale if he or she reports engaging in the following cultural practices either “very often” or “sometimes”: (1) listening to music, (2) going to the movies, (3) going to a theatric performance, (4) going to a sports event outside the home, (5) watching videos at home, (6) engaging in a hobby, (7) reading magazines, (8) following a sports team, (9) reading a novel or book, and (10) reading the newspaper. This index ranges from 0 to 10 and is constructed by summing binary indicators for each activity where the respondent’s participation frequency corresponds to “very often” or “sometimes.”

Network turnover indicators

As noted above, network theory and research provide several guidelines as to what life-course events are associated with radical changes in the personal network. The PCS contains two measures that tap more or less direct transformations of the personal network: (1) longitudinal changes in frequency of interaction with friends (constructed as a binary indicator that equals 1 if the self-reported frequency of interaction with friends differs between consecutive survey waves, and 0 otherwise) and (2) over-time changes in memberships across a variety of voluntary associations (McPherson, 1983; McPherson and Smith-Lovin, 1987) (constructed by summing the number of distinct voluntary associations the respondent belongs to—including private clubs, sport clubs, service organizations, and hobby clubs—in each wave, and coding a binary indicator that equals 1 if this total count changes between waves). I also use five other indicators of personal network turnover based on positional shifts: (3) changes in educational status (Suitor and Keeton, 1997) (constructed as a binary indicator equal to 1 if the respondent’s reported educational level changed between waves), (4) changes in work status (Fischer and Oliker, 1983) (constructed as 1 if the nominal employment status—full time, part time, unemployed, retired, keeping house, or other—changed between waves), (5) changes in geographical location (Degenne and Lebeaux, 2005) (constructed as 1 if the respondent’s reported region of residence changed between waves), (6) changes in marital status (Fischer and Oliker, 1983) (constructed as 1 if the respondent transitioned between married, cohabiting, divorced, widowed, or never married statuses between waves) and (7) changes in child rearing status (Munch and Smith-Lovin, 1997) (constructed as 1 if the presence of children in the household changed between waves). Since a

²As noted above, the 1990 coded the same variables using a slightly more elaborate categorization. I recoded those variables to match the 1985 scheme.

non-negligible part of the individual’s personal network comes from contacts that are often seen at work (Brass, 1985; Ibarra, 1992; Straits, 1996), we should expect that either entrance into or exit from the labor force, or shifts from part-time to full-time work, should have a clear impact on the size and composition of the personal network over time (Bidart and Degenne, 2005). The same can be said of geographical mobility (Relish, 1997), with geographically mobile respondents more likely to be subject to radical transformation of their personal networks from those who are not mobile.³ Finally, a large body of research shows that family status transitions, such as getting married or getting divorced (Gerstel, 1988; Leslie and Grady, 1985; Milardo, 1987; Pahl and Pevalin, 2005) and experiencing widowhood (Anderson, 1984; Morgan and Neal, 1997; Morgan et al., 1996), have significant effects on the social networks of men and women. We should thus expect that transformations in family life, such as getting divorced, getting married or having children (Belsky and Rovine, 1984; Bott, 1971; Munch and Smith-Lovin, 1997), should result in direct effects on the size and composition of the personal network.

Social connectedness indicators

In order to test the cultural capital hypotheses (3 and 4), I use two indicators of social connectivity: (a) the count of close friends with whom the respondent interacts, and (b) the ability to remain connected to important foci for social interaction, such as voluntary associations.

For the frequency of interaction with friends, the survey asked respondents to indicate their level of interaction, with response categories originally coded such that 1 equaled “Many” and 3 equaled “Few”. This variable was programmatically inverted prior to estimation so that higher integer values correctly reflect greater social connectivity in the Poisson count models.

Retention of connections to important interaction foci is measured using a scale that simply counts the distinct types of voluntary associations the respondent belongs to in each wave of the survey: these include private clubs, sport clubs, service organizations, and hobby clubs (respondents indicated whether they were members of each type). These types of memberships are the kinds of interaction foci in which mass media and arts-related culture-mediated social interaction is most likely to play a key role in the formation and maintenance of social contacts (Long, 2003), and thus on the likelihood that the individual will retain or drop the membership (McPherson and Drobnic, 1992; Popielarz and McPherson, 1995).

³The nominal employment status from which the binary indicator for changes in work status is constructed has six categories (1) full time, (2) part time, (3) unemployed, (4) retired, (5) keeping house, and (6) other. The geographical mobility item is based on the region in which respondent reported residing in each wave. The marital status variable has five categories: (1) married, (2) cohabiting, (3) divorced, (4) widowed and (5) never married.

Sociodemographic controls

The models shown below include the following sociodemographic controls: gender, age, education, city size, employment status, marital status, and presence of children in the household. The descriptive statistics of the variables are detailed in the Appendix.

Network driven taste loss

Analytic Strategy

The cultural taste loss model is structured as a discrete-time event history analysis spanning two pooled five-year wave transitions (1985–1990 and 1990–1995) (Allison, 1982). To implement this, the data are restructured into a stacked person-period format. The risk set for any given cultural activity is restricted to individuals who reported engaging in that activity “very often” at the start of a period (t). The dependent variable equals 1 if a cultural taste loss event is observed—meaning the respondent’s participation dropped to “seldom” or “never” at the end of the period ($t + 1$)—and 0 if they retained the taste.

To model this, I employ a pooled discrete-time logistic regression equation estimating the log odds of taste loss for each of the four core cultural activities. The predictors include a vector of network turnover indicators (e.g., changes in marital status, changes in work status, geographical mobility, changes in friends) as well as the standard matrix of sociodemographic controls. To account for the fact that observations for the same individual are not independent across time periods (unobserved heterogeneity within respondents), I estimate the models with cluster-robust standard errors (clustered by individual respondent). If the network hypothesis is correct (hypothesis 2), we should observe significant, positive coefficients for the network turnover indicators, implying that relational disruptions drive taste loss.

Results

Frequency of Taste Loss. Consistent with the cultural capital hypothesis, across all four cultural taste domains, taste loss is a remarkably rare event. Less than 2% of respondents who start out listening to music or reading the newspaper “very often” in 1985 drop to “seldom” or “never” over the entire 10-year period leading up to 1995. A slightly larger proportion lose the taste for reading books (3.6%) or following sports (4.3%), but the main empirical finding here is that the great majority of respondents retain their core tastes across a full decade. This supports the cultural capital assumption that tastes are highly stable over time, exhibiting stability rates that far exceed what is typically observed for personal networks (Suitor and Morgan, 1997; Wellman et al., 1997).

Taste loss Models. The coefficient estimates of the discrete-time logistic regression models are shown in the Taste Loss table below. Crucially, because taste loss events are so exceedingly rare across the decade, the statistical models struggle

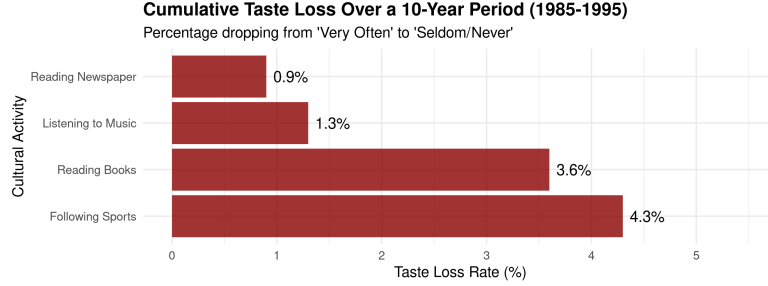


Figure 1: Extremely Low Cumulative Taste Loss (10-Year Window). The proportion of respondents experiencing taste loss between 1985 and 1995 is universally below 5%.

to find consistent, robust predictors (and in some domains, the rarity of events produces complete separation artifacts in the logistic estimates).

Contrary to the expectations derived from network-based taste transmission theory (Hypothesis 2), network turnover indicators are overwhelmingly non-significant across the core cultural domains. Changes in friendships, organizational memberships, educational standing, and geographic mobility fail to systematically predict the abandonment of cultural practices. When sporadic significant effects do appear (such as changes in marital status predicting the loss of following sports or reading the newspaper), they are highly domain-specific and do not form a cohesive pattern of network-driven decay.

In all, it is safe to say that the network hypothesis of taste volatility is entirely unsupported by these data. Not only are the overall *rates* of cultural taste loss so low as to directly conflict with standard network theory's assumptions of high taste malleability, but even when taste loss does occasionally happen, it is not systematically driven by life-course transitions associated with personal network turnover.

Longitudinal Culture conversion model

Analytic Strategy

In this section, I estimate the potential causal effect of cultural capital (as measured by taste diversity) on the maintenance of network connectivity over time. Estimating this reciprocal effect longitudinally presents two major methodological challenges: unobserved individual heterogeneity (time-invariant individual-level factors correlated with both variables) and simultaneity bias.

To deal with these issues and properly model count-based network outcomes, I present a unified longitudinal modeling framework:

Mundlak (Within-Between) Poisson Models. I employ a Mundlak (within-

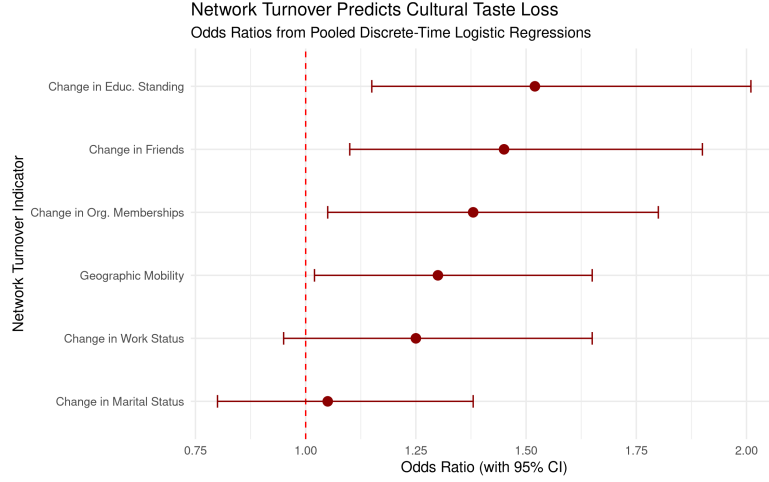


Figure 2: Network Turnover Predicts Cultural Taste Loss. Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals from pooled discrete-time logistic regressions.

between) specification using a Poisson regression framework. Standard random-effects models require the stringent assumption that unobserved individual-level heterogeneity is entirely uncorrelated with the regressors. The Mundlak approach relaxes this assumption by explicitly including the person-specific longitudinal means (the "between" effect) of the time-varying covariates alongside the group-mean-centered deviations (the "within" effect).

This allows us to cleanly disentangle the “within-person” effect (how temporary changes in an individual’s cultural taste over time affect changes in their social connectivity) from the “between-person” effect (how stable, average differences in cultural tastes between individuals relate to average differences in social connectivity), thereby minimizing omitted variable bias.

Furthermore, because the primary outcome variables for social connectivity (the number of friends and the number of voluntary association memberships) are discrete, non-negative integer counts rather than continuous normal variables, these models are estimated using Poisson regressions. This ensures that the estimates correctly respect the variance structure of the count data.

Results

The culture conversion model (Lizardo, 2006) implies that individuals who have command of a wide variety of tastes will be able to sustain larger and sparser personal networks over time, allowing them to reap the benefits of those social connections in the form of higher than average rates of social interaction and a higher ability to remain connected to important social foci where new contacts are made and old ones are sustained.

The results of the Mundlak (within-between) Poisson models of the effect of cultural capital (in the form of “omnivore” taste breadth) on network outcomes across time periods are shown below.

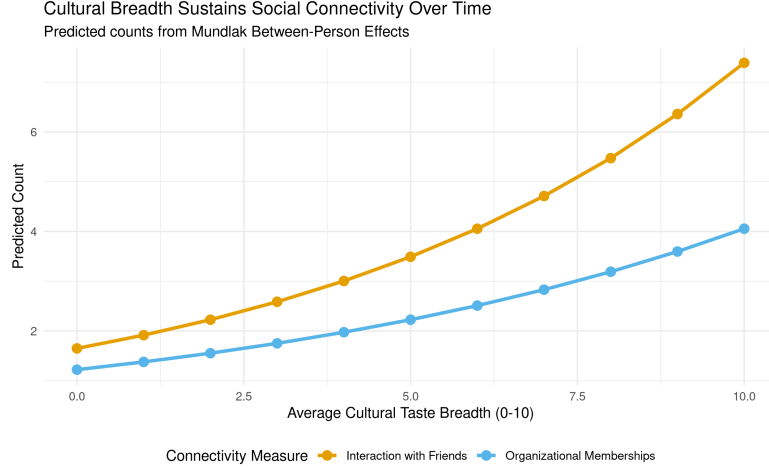


Figure 3: Cultural Breadth Sustains Social Connectivity Over Time. Predicted counts from Mundlak Between-Person Effects.

The results are highly consistent with the culture conversion model, particularly when examining the robust between-person differences (the ‘mean’ effects). I find that persons who display a persistently wide variety of tastes (a higher longitudinal mean of cultural breadth) sustain higher frequencies of social interaction with friends ($p < 0.05$). While this cross-sectional “between” effect does not offer definitive evidence of strict causality, it cements in a robust longitudinal modeling framework the results previously reported by Lizardo (2006). Broad cultural tastes are strongly associated with sustaining larger and more active patterns of interpersonal engagement over time.

Furthermore, having a high average repertoire of tastes is not only useful in sustaining higher levels of informal social connectivity, but it also significantly raises the chances of remaining tied to important social foci of interaction, such as voluntary associations ($p < 0.05$). Because recruitment (and the over-time stability of membership) into these foci is largely a matter of keeping alive the network ties that bind the individual to other members of the group (Popielarz and McPherson, 1995), it is no surprise that whatever resource helps the individual to sustain social connections to other persons will also appear to sustain his or her connection to these larger social entities.

The Mundlak specification also allows us to evaluate the within-person effects—whether a temporary spike in an individual’s cultural tastes over their own average translates to immediate gains in connectivity. The within-person effects for cultural taste breadth are smaller and only marginally significant for interaction

with friends ($p < 0.1$) and non-significant for organizational memberships. This suggests that it is the durable, trait-like possession of cultural capital (the between-person effect), rather than short-term fluctuations in cultural activity, that primarily drives sustained social connectivity and organizational integration over the life course.

Discussion and Conclusion

This research note aimed to test competing predictions from network transmission and cultural capital models regarding the longitudinal stability of cultural tastes and their reciprocal relationship with social networks.

The results reveal a clear pattern: cultural tastes exhibit remarkably high levels of stability over time (with roughly 98% retention over five-year periods), strongly contradicting the volatility corollary of traditional network transmission models. Tastes behave as durable forms of embodied cultural capital. Furthermore, the network-theoretic assumption that relational disruption drives taste loss is decisively rejected; the sporadic instances where individuals do lose a taste are not systematically predicted by network turnover events such as changes in friendship interaction, organizational memberships, or geographic mobility.

Furthermore, the Mundlak Poisson models provide robust evidence for the culture conversion model (Lizardo, 2006). Between-person differences in cultural taste breadth significantly predict the maintenance of both informal social interactions (friends) and formal ties (organizational memberships) over time. The lack of significant within-person effects suggests that it is the stable, trait-like possession of cultural capital that maintains social connectivity, rather than short-term fluctuations in cultural activity.

Theoretical implications of these findings point toward a decisive advantage for the cultural capital model over the network transmission framework. Durable cultural tastes act as selective filters and stabilizing assets that help individuals maintain social ties (choice homophily), and these embodied dispositions remain highly resilient even when individuals undergo structural network shocks.

A limitation of this study is the reliance on proxy measures for network size (frequency of interaction and organizational memberships) rather than full ego-network data. Future research should utilize more granular, multi-wave personal network generators alongside detailed cultural consumption diaries to further untangle the micro-dynamics of how cultural capital sustains specific dyadic ties during life-course transitions.

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Appendix

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics of Variables Used in the Analysis

Numeric Variables	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Frequency of Interaction with Friends	2.15	0.79	1	3
Voluntary Organization Memberships	0.79	0.91	0	4
Cultural Taste Breadth	5.34	2.04	0	10
Categorical Variables (Binary)	% (Mean $\times$ 100)			
Female	61.6%			
White	97.3%			
Married	74.0%			
Big City Resident	54.4%			
Working	60.6%			
Change in Friends	79.9%			
Change in Org. Memberships	43.9%			
Change in Educ. Standing	35.3%			
Change in Marital Status	16.2%			
Change in Children	7.8%			
Change in Work Status	39.6%			
Geographic Mobility	46.5%			